

Maria Silva

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LLB and LLM graduate with direct experience advising clients on family, housing, welfare and debt matters at Citizens Advice, and a year's disputes placement at a leading commercial firm. Experienced in client interviewing, drafting correspondence and applications, preparing court materials and bundles, maintaining organised case files, and managing competing deadlines across multiple matters. Clear and empathetic communicator with vulnerable clients. Interested in developing a career in family law.

EDUCATION

Comparative and International Dispute Resolution LLM — Merit Sept 2024 – Oct 2025

Queen Mary University of London

- Modules in international arbitration, dispute resolution procedure, evidence analysis and legal research
- Dissertation: data protection and GDPR development across jurisdictions
- Transnational Law and Governance Applied module (data privacy and democracy) — 75%

Law LLB — 2:1 Sept 2020 – June 2024

University College London

- Modules included Alternative Dispute Resolution, Advanced Contract Law, Commercial Law and Company Law

International Foundation Programme, Law and International Relations Sept 2019 – June 2020

King's College London

- Awarded the Leaders of Tomorrow prize (top 20 of 200-student cohort; partial funding toward undergraduate degree)

EXPERIENCE

Citizens Advice East Berkshire · Maidenhead July 2026 – Present

Legal Adviser

- Advises clients on family, housing, welfare benefits, employment, debt and consumer matters; takes detailed factual statements and establishes chronologies to identify legal and evidential issues
- Manages matters from initial instruction through to submission: drafts correspondence, prepares applications and document schedules, maintains confidential case records and meets deadlines
- Assesses eligibility against statutory criteria; identifies evidential gaps; researches complex points of law to support client cases
- Translates complex legal and procedural requirements into clear, practical guidance for vulnerable individuals, including those going through separations and custody disputes

Bryan Cave Leighton Paisner LLP (BCLP) · London Feb 2024 – Aug 2024

Legal Placement Student — Real Estate Disputes

- Supported hearing preparation: reviewed documents, prepared electronic bundles and assisted with skeleton arguments and court materials
- Conducted legal and factual research on rights of light, easements, leasehold issues and landlord and tenant disputes
- Prepared client notes; maintained matter records via iManage; assisted with court filings, hearing arrangements and deadline tracking
- Managed large volumes of confidential documents across several matters with competing deadlines

Bryan Cave Leighton Paisner LLP (BCLP) · London Aug 2023 – Feb 2024

Legal Placement Student — International Arbitration

- Supported a complex investment arbitration: reviewed and organised evidence for procedural submissions and the Claimant's memorial; drafted procedural orders and procedural histories

- Became the only junior supporting the team shortly before a significant deadline: coordinated documents, tracked outstanding actions and helped ensure on-time submission
- Maintained structured electronic case files and monitored procedural deadlines; liaised with the client on required documents
- Received feedback from a partner and associate that performance was comparable to a newly qualified solicitor

Q-Legal · Remote

Oct 2024 – Jan 2025

Legal Adviser

- Managed a data-privacy matter from client instruction through to a formal written advice letter, under a qualified solicitor's supervision
- Researched UK GDPR and Data Protection Act 2018 obligations; identified compliance risks and recommended practical mitigations
- Translated complex statutory requirements into clear, commercially focused advice; coordinated with client and supervising solicitor to meet deadline

Adobe · London

June 2022 – Aug 2022

Legal Intern

- Reviewed and amended software licensing agreements; identified contractual risks and assessed alignment with internal legal and compliance requirements
- Reviewed confidentiality and data-processing provisions; researched UK GDPR, EU GDPR and cross-border data transfer requirements
- Liaised with sales, legal and international business teams to resolve contractual queries and communicate amendments to stakeholders
- Prepared and delivered an internal presentation on breach-of-contract risks and mitigation measures

SKILLS

Languages: Portuguese (native), English (fluent), Spanish (basic)

Technical skills: Legal and commercial research; client interviewing and factual analysis; document drafting and correspondence; Microsoft Word, Excel and PowerPoint; iManage; legal research databases; electronic court filing portals; electronic bundling; case management and time-recording systems

Case and evidence management: Evidence review, hearing bundle preparation, procedural histories, case-file organisation, deadline tracking across multiple concurrent matters